

lines and other posts to see how the community fits together. Jumping in with a harsh opinion won't create a good first impression, and the Web, like life, is all about making a good first impression.

4. Check your grammar. More and more often in discussion groups, members are chastising people who use bad grammar or misspell words. Cothrel says that nothing kills an argument for him like seeing a simple word misspelled consistently. He says you have to wonder: If people can't spell, do they really know what they're talking about?
5. Don't ask about e-mail you just sent. Don't buttonhole someone in the hall or telephone him five minutes after you send a lengthy e-mail and ask him what he thinks about it. Give him a chance to read it, digest it and reply via e-mail. According to Cothrel, more and more people consider discussions about e-mail messages a waste of time.
6. Follow threads you start. When you start a thread on a discussion forum, especially if you asked a question, follow that thread. And if you solve the problem you asked about, tell the board. Likewise, Cothrel points out, if the advice you received from the other members led you to a solution, be sure to tell them.
7. Don't use instant messaging for long messages. Betsy Waldinger, vice president at Chicago-based OptionsXpress Inc., spends a lot of her day working on an online customer-service chat system that operates a lot like instant messaging. She says it's important to send short messages and to break up long ones over many screens. If you don't, she says, you force the people on the other end to wade through an overly long message - and you keep them waiting for an answer while you type.
8. Send a message before you drop in. At companies where